

SOFTWARE IMPLEMENTATION

Moving Fernwood Studio from Spreadsheets to ClickUp

A simulated 6-week migration of a small agency's task management from a shared spreadsheet into ClickUp

Folashekemi Vanessa Joshua

Project Manager / Systems Implementation lead

Simulated / not real client work

The scenario

Fernwood Studio is a fictional 15-person creative & marketing agency running about 20 client accounts, all tracked in one shared Google Sheet the "Master Tracker."

The sheet has outgrown itself: overwritten rows, no notifications, and three missed client deliverables last quarter. I was brought in to plan and run the migration to ClickUp, as Systems Implementation Lead.

NOTE

This is a simulated practice project applying a structured implementation approach to a tools migration, built to demonstrate PM and systems coordination skills. The agency and figures are fictional.

Project brief

Client	Fernwood Studio — fictional 15-person creative & marketing agency
Project	Migrate task management from a shared spreadsheet into ClickUp
Objective	Zero lost tasks, under 2 hours onboarding per person, 100% team adoption by week 6
Duration	6 weeks, plus a 30-day post-launch check-in
Sponsor	Fernwood Studio Operations Director
Implementation Lead	Folashekemi Vanessa Joshua (simulated role)
Approach	Audit → build → migrate → train → run in parallel → go live
Team involved	Operations Director, 6 Account Managers, 6 Creatives, 3 Freelancers

Why the spreadsheet broke down

Overwritten rows

15 people editing one sheet at once, updates silently overwrote each other with no version history

No notifications

Approaching deadlines relied on someone remembering to check the sheet, nothing alerted anyone

No workload visibility

Account managers couldn't see who was overloaded until a deadline was already missed

Manual status updates

Client updates were re-typed into emails by hand, separate from the sheet itself

Result: 3 client deliverables missed last quarter, traced back to tasks lost in the sheet

The goal

Move all active client work into ClickUp within **6 weeks**, with **zero lost tasks** and full team adoption without disrupting live client deliverables.

0

tasks lost in migration

<2 hrs

onboarding time per person

100%

team logging tasks in ClickUp by week 6

Requirements

- Every active client task migrated with owner, due date and status intact
- Custom fields matching the sheet's existing columns client, task type, priority, estimated hours
- Automatic notifications as deadlines approach
- A per-account-manager dashboard showing their clients' task status at a glance
- Time tracking, since some clients are billed hourly
- A permission structure so freelancers only see their own assigned tasks

Scope & deliverables

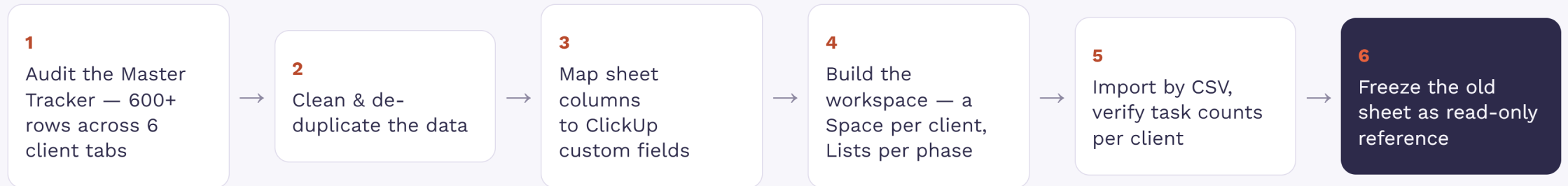
IN SCOPE

- Migrating all 6 active client workspaces
- 3 custom views: My Tasks, Account Manager Dashboard, Studio Calendar
- Training for all 15 staff, by role
- A 2-week parallel run before go-live

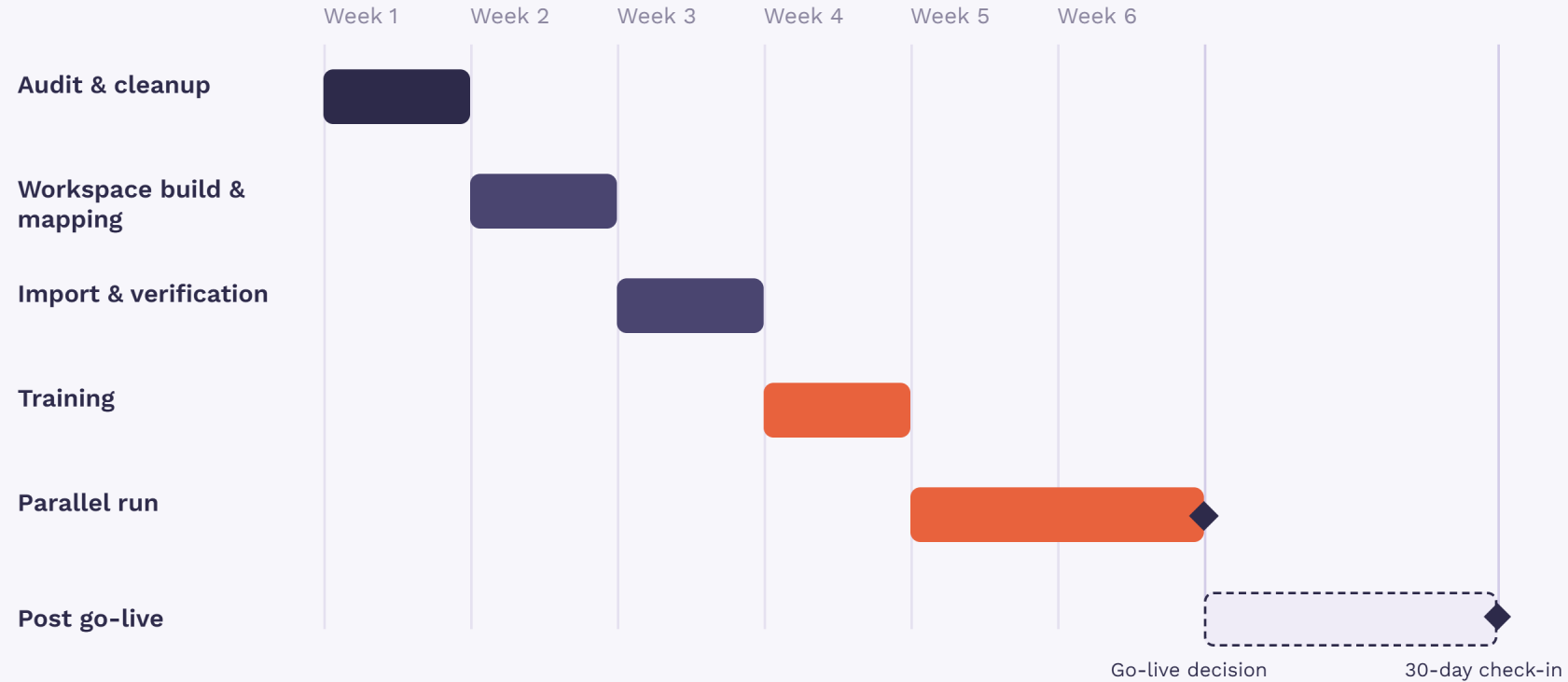
OUT OF SCOPE

- Archived/completed client projects — stay in Sheets for reference
- Accounting software integration (phase 2)
- Automations beyond due-date reminders

Migration plan



Implementation timeline — 6 weeks



Weeks 5–6 run both systems in parallel; the go-live decision at the end of week 6 confirms full cutover.

Testing checklist

- Task counts match the old sheet exactly for all 6 clients
- Due-date reminders fire correctly, tested on 3 sample tasks
- Freelancer permissions confirmed — 2 test accounts can't see other clients' tasks
- Time tracking exports correctly into a summary report
- Mobile app tested by 2 staff for on-the-go task logging

Training plan

Session	Audience	Focus
All-hands kickoff (30 min)	Whole studio	Why we're moving, high-level tour of ClickUp
Dashboards & reporting	6 Account Managers	Reading the client dashboard, flagging at-risk tasks
Task updates & time tracking	6 Creatives	Logging status changes, tracking billable hours
Basic task view (1:1, 15 min)	3 Freelancers	Finding and updating their own assigned tasks
Office hours	Whole studio	Drop-in support during the parallel-run weeks

A 1-page quick reference guide is issued per role alongside its session

Rollout plan

Weeks 5–6

Parallel run: all new tasks created in ClickUp; the old sheet stays live as a read-only reference

End of Wk 6

Go/no-go review, 90%+ of tasks logged correctly in ClickUp triggers full go-live

Week 7

Master Tracker fully archived and ClickUp becomes the single source of truth

Day 30

Check-in to catch stragglers and confirm the new process has stuck

Risks & blockers

Type	Description	Mitigation
Risk	Staff revert to old habits, emailing updates instead of logging in ClickUp	Account managers require a ClickUp link in every status update, not a sheet reference
Risk	Freelancers, paid hourly and less engaged, skip training	Recorded Loom walkthrough plus a mandatory 15-minute 1:1 before their next task
Risk	Data-mapping errors during import silently drop tasks	Line-by-line count verification per client before the old sheet is frozen
Issue (occurred)	One client's tabs used a different column structure than the rest of the sheet	Manually remapped that client's fields — added 2 days to the migration schedule

Before & after

BEFORE — THE SHEET

- One shared Google Sheet, no version control
- No notifications, deadlines relied on memory
- Status updates re-typed by hand into emails
- No visibility into individual workload
- Frequent overwritten rows and version conflicts

AFTER — CLICKUP

- A dedicated Space per client, with full change history
- Automatic reminders as due dates approach
- Client status pulled straight from live dashboards
- Account manager dashboards show workload at a glance
- Permission-based access, no accidental overwrites

Tools used

ClickUp

The target platform: Spaces, custom fields, dashboards and time tracking

Google Sheets

The source Master Tracker, audited and later frozen as reference

Miro

Mapping the current and target workflows before the build

Loom

Recorded training walkthroughs for freelancers and asynchronous staff

Slack

Rollout communications and daily office-hours support

Zapier

Connecting ClickUp status changes to Slack notifications

Final result & retrospective

WHAT WORKED

- All 612 tasks across 6 client workspaces migrated with zero losses, verified line by line
- 93% team adoption by the end of week 6 go-live approved on schedule
- Account manager dashboards caught 2 at-risk deadlines in week 5 alone that the old sheet would have missed

WHAT I'D IMPROVE

- Budget extra time upfront for any client whose sheet doesn't match the standard tab structure
- Make freelancer training one mandatory group session rather than optional 1:1s, 2 freelancers didn't finish until week 7
- Pilot the permission structure with one client before rolling it out to all six